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Literacy Learning as Social Practice
Warner School for Education
University of Rochester
Fall 2024

1. **Unit Context:** This district is a diverse suburban community with various socioeconomic backgrounds. The school is predominantly white but within it, there are first-generation immigrants including Latinx, African American, and Asian populations. This is the program I created for a 10th-grade Social Studies class, focusing on America's Civil Rights Movement. These students are not in upper grades, it serves as an opportunity to include their various cultural perspectives. This unit would be accessible through scaffolded activities, visuals, and different kinds of formats such as group work and readings that are accessible. The unit will utilize video clips, art, and music to fully impact the various learners' abilities in the historical material. This unit would extend itself to empathy, critical thinking, and relevant engagement with contemporary struggles for racial justice that might touch students' own experiences around marginalization or oppression.
2. **Unit Description and Purpose:** The purpose of this unit is to introduce and educate students about America's Civil Rights Movement (1950s - 1970s), examining the history of racial injustice, significant events, figures, and the tactics utilized by activists to confront systematic racism. During this unit, students will analyze primary and secondary sources to highlight the courage of activists during the Civil Rights Movement. Students will look closely into the movement's accomplishments and shortcomings, reflecting on its impact on American society and the influence it has created in society.
3. **Literacies Framework:**

Identity: Students will explore identity, especially about race, power, and language. They will dive into the identities of key figures who fought in the Civil Rights Movement. They fought for racial equality, many of whom were from historically marginalized backgrounds—exploring their full identities to see these figures not only as symbols but as individuals with hopes, dreams, and flaws. By connecting with these historical figures on a deeper level students will see the power of individual voices in forming history and advocating for injustice.

Skills: During this unit. Students will grasp research and literacy skills by analyzing different sources such as academic texts. They will take part in gathering evidence from

different sources and engage in critically analyzing for reliability and perspectives. Students' skills in reading, writing, and creating presentations will be focused on.

Intellect: The unit will have students study the various tactics or strategies used by the different leaders of the movements in which they make comparisons between nonviolent direct action and the more radical approaches. The unit will introduce students to legal reform, grassroots organizing, and media representation as part of the movement's successes and/or challenges. From this point students will also be instructed to examine how the Civil Rights Movement influenced other movements across the globe, linking events from the past where patterns of resistance and solidarity have been evident. In addition, students will reflect on how the legal system supports or contests racial inequality.

Criticality: Students will think critically about the history of race power and privilege by questioning the societal structures that maintain or heighten racial inequality as well as understand how these systems replicate themselves in contemporary society. They will examine how the contributions of particular figures, often women, or lesser-known activists were denied or minimized and consider how race, class, and gender intersected to mold African Americans' experiences during the Civil Rights Movement. Students will challenge the historical narrative: why were voices silenced and how has this impacted public memory? Students investigate how active movements continue the fight against similar systems of oppression.

Joy: Students will find joy in connecting with the cultural expressions that formed from the Civil Rights Movement. They'll be given prompts to develop their artistic responses to the movement, poetic, visual, or musical: understandings of the movement into forms of expression that reflect both the pain and the joy of dissent. Students will feel the emotional force of the struggle to fight against injustices and the system, as they build empathy and personal connection to the history and figures they study.

Teacher: Nisa Gulbay	Grade Level: 9th Grade History
Voices of Courage: The Civil Rights Movement and Its Impacts	
Length of Unit: 1.5 weeks: 7 lessons (1 hour per lesson)	

Week 1	Lesson 1: Introduction to Civil Rights Movement: Historical context and Who were the leaders of the movement? - Discuss the historical context of segregation, Jim Crow laws, and the civil rights struggles Jim Crow Laws and Racial Segregation in America The Civil Rights Movement: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nje1U7jJOHI - Students will explore the identities of key Civil Rights figures like Rosa Parks, Martin Luther King Jr., Rosa Parks and more  Use of posters around the class for visual aid	Homework: Watch: Rosa Parks interview (1995) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bqiQqM9nQ0U Encourage students to focus on Rosa Parks identity and her influence on her activism in the Montgomery Bus Boycott Read the biographies of key Civil Rights Figures https://naacp.org/find-resources/history-explained/civil-rights-leaders
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	● Reflect on how race, background, and gender influence activism ● In small groups, students will research one of the key leaders focusing on their identity and their impact on the movement. Present to class.	
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Week 1	Lesson 2: Protest Tactics and Strategies of the Civil Rights Movement: Nonviolence Objectives: ● Students will understand the tenets of nonviolent philosophy ● Explain the reasons civil rights activists adopted nonviolence as a method for securing equal rights during the 1950s and 1960s ● Identify and assess the effectiveness of different nonviolent strategies civil rights activists employed ----- Classwork: ● Analyze selected chapters of Dr. Martin Luther King's <i>Stride Toward Freedom</i>, his memoir of the Montgomery bus boycott. Select a few key quotes to share out https://nationalhumanitiescenter.org/ows/seminars/aahistory/Pilgrimage.pdf ● Montgomery Bus Boycott; integration of Little Rock Central	Homework: Reflect on the questions below: Who didn't want equal rights for African Americans? Give examples of their opposition. Why would someone be willing to risk his or her life in the struggle for civil rights?
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High School in Little Rock;
lunch-counter sit-ins; voter
registration drives; Birmingham
Children's March; 1963 March on
Washington; march from Selma to
Montgomery.

Select one of the events above and explain
how it practiced nonviolence tactics,
effectiveness and see how it connects to the
principle of nonviolence listed on the
handout

Principles of Nonviolence

Dr. Martin Luther King Jr.

1. Nonviolence is a way of life for courageous people.
2. Nonviolence seeks to win friendship and understanding.
3. Nonviolence seeks to defeat injustice, not people.
4. Nonviolence holds that suffering can educate and transform.
5. Nonviolence chooses love instead of hate.
6. Nonviolence believes that the universe is on the side of justice.

These principles are derived from "Pilgrimage to Nonviolence" in Dr. King's book *Stride Toward Freedom*.

Week 1	Check-in: Lesson 3: Protest Tactics and Strategies of the Civil Rights Movement (continued) Objective: • Students will explore different protest tactics • Students will practice research, critical thinking, and collaboration skills while analyzing protests and strategies in groups by connecting them to themes of identity and justice Classwork: • Group work and presentations: Review protest tactics (such as nonviolent, direct action, marches, sit-ins, freedom rides). With the	Homework: Watch <i>Eyes on the Prize: Ain't Scared of Your Jails</i> (1960-1961) https://video.rmpbs.org/video/aint-scared-of-your-jails-1960-1961-sktghc/ Role of Black College students during Lunch Counter sit-ins, Freedom Riders, and more
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	assigned protest/tactic answer the following questions: - Compare and contrast the different tactics utilized by figures - What was the goal of the protest tactic? - Who were the key figures involved? - What was the immediate outcome and long-term impact of the tactic on the movement? Students will create a brief presentation to the class about their findings	
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Week 1	Lesson 4: Legal Challenges and the Judiciary's Role in Civil Rights Objectives: ● Students will analyze how legal hurdles have been instrumental in attaining the goals of the Civil Rights Movement ● How the judiciary system both served as a tool and a barrier Class activity: ● Watch <i>Road to Brown</i> https://search.worldcat.org/title/The-road-to-Brown/oclc/54506917	Homework: Continue working on the Civil Rights timeline project
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	● Answer post-film discussion questions with classmates ● Introduce the timeline project, begin brainstorming 5 or more key events for the timeline project and formats of presentation - Based on significant victories mentioned in class, working backward from the victory makes a timeline of the Civil Rights Movement with visuals, actions, resistance, and figures. Focus on 5 or more key events that led to the victory. You may use many different formats to create this timeline such as drawing, digital, PowerPoint, prezzi, recording, etc.	

Week 1	Lesson 5:	Homework:
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	Music in the Civil Rights Movement Objective: • Students will explore Civil Rights movement musical masterpieces • Explain how the Civil Rights Movement used music to express pain, hope, and unity Class activity: • Audio clips of Civil Rights songs - “We Shall Overcome” https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nM39QUiAsoM	Continue working on the Civil Rights timeline project. Presentations will be in the next class!
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	We Shall Overcome, lyrics We Shall Overcome, we shall overcome We shall overcome someday. Oh, deep in my heart, I do believe, We shall overcome someday. We are not afraid, we are not afraid, We are not afraid today. Oh, deep in my heart, I do believe, We shall overcome someday. We are not alone, we are not alone We are not alone today Oh, deep in my heart, I do believe, We are not alone today. The truth will make us free, the truth will make us free, The truth will make us free someday. Oh, deep in my heart, I do believe, We shall overcome someday. We'll walk hand in hand, we'll walk hand in hand, We'll walk hand in hand someday. Oh, deep in my heart, I do believe, We shall overcome someday. The Lord will see us through, the Lord will see us through, The Lord will see us through someday. Oh, deep in my heart, I do believe, We shall overcome someday. Black and white together, Black and white together, Black and white together someday. Oh, deep in my heart, I do believe, We shall overcome someday. We shall all be free, we shall all be free, We shall all be free someday. Oh, deep in my heart, I do believe, - "A Change Is Gonna Come" https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fPr3yvkHYsE	
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	“A Change Is Gonna Come” I was born by the river in a little tent Oh and just like the river I've been running ever since It's been a long, a long time coming But I know a change gonna come, oh yes it will. It's been too hard living but I'm afraid to die Cause I don't know what's up there beyond the sky It's been a long, a long time coming But I know a change gonna come, oh yes it will. I go to the movie and I go downtown Somebody keep telling me don't hang around It's been a long, a long time coming But I know a change gonna come, oh yes it will. Then I go to my brother And I say brother help me please But he winds up knockin' me Back down on my knees. There been times that I thought I couldn't last for long But now I think I'm able to carry on It's been a long, a long time coming But I know a change gonna come, oh yes it will. —Sam Cooke, 1954 ● Discuss: How did music inspire and unite people during the Civil Rights Movement? How does music continue to play a role in advocating for social change today?	
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Week 2	Lesson 6: Victories ● Presentation day! ● Students will evaluate the victories of the civil rights movement ● Use Padlet during class to give	Homework: Be proud of all your work and knowledge! Share your Civil Rights Movement timeline project
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	feedback on your classmates' presentations https://padlet.com/ 	with a family or friend.
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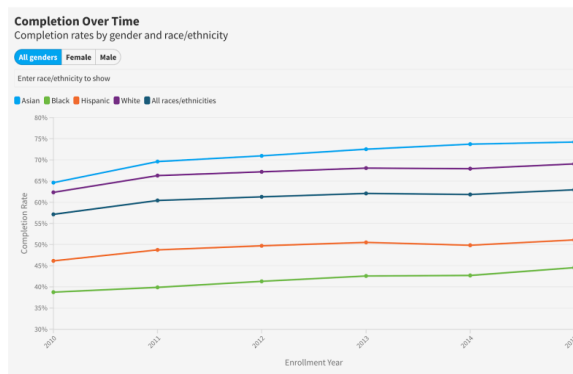
Week 2	Lesson 7: The Work That Remains Objectives: • Students will read data to see if inequality persists • Students will reflect on why inequalities still exist • Reflect on their role in advocating for justice. Classwork: Pose reflection question • The civil rights struggles of the past	Homework: Write a one-page journal entry on your experiences in the present context and ways in which you can personally advocate for justice in your community school or everyday life. Watch the inspirational clip:
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fifty years have recorded visible successes; for instance, today, there are no "Colored Only" signs. What then about the invisible areas in life?

- In this lesson, use data on education, employment, and income to examine whether African Americans have reached equality in these crucial areas and evaluate what remains to be done to create a truly just and equitable society.

Can Kids Change the World? | The Civil Rights Movement

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8b3Y9xVvQzw>

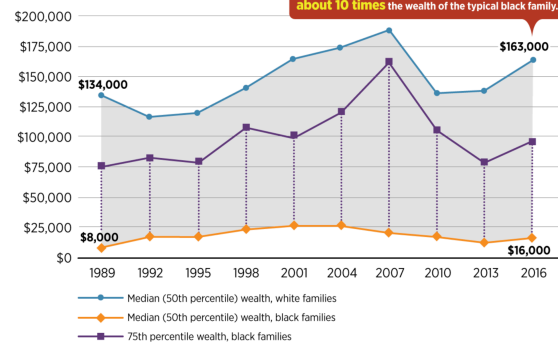


Credit: National Student Clearinghouse's DEI Data Lab 2023

1. What is being progressed in this chart?
2. By how much did the completion rates for white students exceed those of their Black counterparts in 2010? (Hint: What was the percentage point difference?)
3. Based on the data, did college completion rates improve for all students from 2010 to 2015?
4. Why might it be that Black and Hispanic students have lower completion rates than their white peers?
5. What can be done to narrow the gap in college completion between Black

and white students?

White/Black Wealth Gap



■ FEDERAL RESERVE BANK OF ST. LOUIS

Notes: Dollar values are CPI-U adjusted to 2016 dollars and rounded to the nearest \$1,000.

Sources: Federal Reserve Board's Survey of Consumer Finances and authors' calculations.

1. According to the chart, how does the wealth of the typical white family compare to the wealth of the typical black family in 2016?
2. How might this wealth gap affect opportunities for education, housing, and healthcare for black families compared to white families?
3. In what ways could this wealth gap impact future generations?
4. How does understanding the wealth gap influence the way you think about social justice and economic inequality?

Create a Sample:

Example Journal Entry for mini unit Lesson 7

Unit Reflection:

Designing this unit has been extremely fun and rewarding for me. It was fun to explore many different ways to teach such an important lesson. I was pushed to think critically about how to best engage learners in comprehending the complexity and power of the civil rights movement through the lens of culturally responsive teaching. A main challenge I faced was ensuring all five of Muhammed's pursuits were integrated into the lesson while focusing on the historical content. My main goal was to teach the historical events with the emotional and artistic expressions tied to the Civil Rights Movement. To allow engagement by inspiring students with the unit's information without overwhelming them. Each unit strives to give students space to form connections to the material and realize the relevance of these historical struggles and activists to their own lives and the world they live in.

Mohammed's framework, specifically the emphasis on joy as an essential pursuit in literacy and education was what inspired me through this unit planning. While the civil rights movement was a time of struggle and pain, it was also filled with victories and emotions of hope, unity, and joy. I wanted to create a unit that showcased the hardships and triumphs of the movement while also allowing students to understand how joy, music, unity, and resistance worked together to form strong expressions. When I was in high school my favorite unit was the one in which I learned about the Civil Rights Movement. I was in awe of the activist's identities, courage, and resistance. While our lessons in high school were heavily based on main events and key figures, I tried to implement more of the lesser-known names along with the forms of art created during the movement. Such as the music piece "We Shall Overcome" and the lyrical meaning. I believe the artistic component of the period served as a tool for resistance and

empowerment reflecting the emotional landscape. The incorporation of the artistic and pursuit of joy pushed me to think more creatively and academically while teaching history.

Throughout the semester we worked with the Muhammed framework, this mini-unit allowed me to apply my understanding of literacy and lesson planning as a future educator. The focus on criticality challenged me to reflect on opportunities for students to question societal structures. Understanding concepts such as racial inequality and its existence in contemporary society. Reflecting on the systematic barriers that still exist and how they impact African Americans and other minorities. It felt rewarding knowing that students would benefit from understanding these patterns in modern and historical contexts. My minority students will feel empowered and connected to history.

This unit is about empowering students and creating a space that is centered on students and equity. The historical facts are important however empowering students to view themselves as important agents of change in their lives and societies is even more important. Similar to the figures of the civil rights movement the students in my class have unique identities, values, and goals. Moving forward, my goal is to focus on equity-aligned literacies that will center the curriculum on the identities of students. This focus will ensure students remain engaged and have a meaningful and personal relationship to the content. As a future educator, I stay committed to creating safe spaces where opportunities for critical dialogue along with personal reflections are common practice. Implementing Muhammed's five pursuits into my mini-lessons has allowed me to focus on the larger purpose of education and literacy. The purpose stands to empower students, question their societies, and the systems of power, and find joy in their learning process.

Nisa, This is an exceptional body of work you have produced. You quietly did the work this semester that speaks volumes in this unit. You have a strong and powerful voice in this work and I encourage you to continue pursuing units that speak to the 5 pursuits as you have here. You are quite skilled at it!

Consider your commitment to provide SEL and layer in more SEL in the classes – there is a burden that this unit could place on marginalized students and making space each class for wellness or simply to lay down the struggles for a moment is an ethic of care students need.

Really wonderful work, and I would love to highlight it as an example in future classes with your permission. See Rubric below for more feedback:

Identity 3	The unit deeply engages students in exploring and expressing their identities. Lessons incorporate diverse perspectives, student agency, and self-expression. You layered many opportunities into the mini-unit for students to bring their unique perspectives to the learning community. I appreciated the different ways that students could demonstrate their strengths and understandings too.	The unit supports identity exploration and incorporates opportunities for self-expression, though depth may be limited.	The unit addresses identity but offers limited opportunities for students to explore or express their own identities.	The unit minimally or inadequately addresses student identity.
Skills 3	The unit effectively builds essential literacy skills, ensuring students develop both foundational and higher-order skills with clear, purposeful activities I appreciated the use of varied sources and that you are wrapping up the unit with a cross disciplinary approach – could be a great opportunity to partner with a math teacher to deepen understanding of analyzing trends AND making inferences from the data	The unit builds key literacy skills, with clear objectives and activities to support skill development.	The unit touches on skill-building but lacks clear objectives or activities to ensure skill development.	The unit fails to effectively build or address literacy skills.
Intellect 3	The unit challenges students intellectually, engaging them with complex concepts, ideas, and texts that deepen their understanding and knowledge. You did a wonderful job of creating a rigorous yet scaffolded learning experience for your students – really well done!	The unit supports intellectual growth, engaging students with relevant concepts and texts that develop their knowledge.	The unit introduces some complex ideas, but intellectual engagement may be surface-level or inconsistent.	The unit offers little to no intellectual challenge for students.
Criticality 3	The unit meaningfully engages students in critical thinking about power, equity, and social justice. Students are encouraged to question and challenge societal norms. You have a very strong handle on Criticality, and you have an element of this in nearly every class. The fact that you built in classes discussing the present-day inequities demonstrates your commitment to this pursuit – many relegate these struggles to the past as if these same challenges do not exist today. You pointed to the pervasiveness of systemic and institutionalized inequities and how they remain the social justice issue of our time- with critical literacies being an antidote	The unit addresses criticality, prompting students to think about power and social justice, though depth may vary.	The unit touches on criticality but lacks consistent engagement with power, equity, or social justice issues.	The unit does not adequately engage students in critical thinking.
Joy 3	The unit effectively incorporates joy, love, and aesthetic fulfillment. Lessons foster creativity, curiosity, and passion for learning. Great work layering in the different modalities and creative opportunities. You also highlighted how joy is evident because of the reflection on the struggles - joy can come out of reflection, resistance, and is a component of resilience.	The unit incorporates joy and engagement, though opportunities for creativity and fulfillment may be limited.	The unit includes some moments of joy or creativity, but these are not central to the learning experience.	The unit lacks engagement or fails to incorporate elements of joy.
Lesson Plan Coherence & Engagement 3	Lessons are well-structured, coherent, and engaging. The learning activities align with objectives, and students are meaningfully involved throughout the unit.	Lessons are organized and aligned with objectives. Students are engaged, though some activities may lack depth.	Lessons are somewhat organized but may lack coherence or alignment with objectives. Engagement may be inconsistent.	Lessons are disorganized, lack engagement, or do not align with objectives.
Sample Assignment 3	The sample assignment is thoughtful, detailed, and provides a strong model for students. It reflects deep empathy and realistic expectations for learners. What a beautiful sample- I love how in your sample you layer in SEL in a seamless way like that- so well done!	The sample assignment is clear and demonstrates reasonable expectations, though may lack detail or depth.	The sample assignment is underdeveloped and provides limited guidance for students.	The sample assignment is incomplete or does not offer a helpful model.
Reflection 4	The reflection is highly insightful and demonstrates deep personal and professional growth. It thoughtfully connects Muhammad's framework, course concepts, and future teaching. Wonderful commitments!	The reflection is thoughtful and demonstrates professional growth. Connections to Muhammad's framework and teaching are clear, though depth may vary.	The reflection touches on personal and professional growth but lacks depth or strong connections to course concepts.	The reflection is superficial or fails to connect to the course concepts.